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### CST 301: For the Love of Food

*MIDTERM\_essay*

by

Group\_35

Section-08

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## **The Political Hearth: Negotiating Purity, Gender, and Rank in the Tamil Brahmin Kitchen**

Emotion, status and power are associated with food concepts, and define the way people eat. In this essay, we make a comparison of ideas from Arjun Appadurai (1981) and Utsa Ray (2009), regarding gastro-politics and women labor in cooking to observe the power relations and exclusion based on gender and purity in a Tamil Brahmin kitchen during ritual meals. Even the kitchen that may seem an ordinary place at first is in fact a crowded area where the bodies are disciplined and the social lines are drawn. According to Appadurai (1981), the politics of food exchange build hierarchies and are challenged and thus the kitchen is a political space. Ray (2009) also argues that taste, aesthetics may obscure the women's work, which gives the work some moral framing.

In this essay, gendered labour and conceptualizations of ritual purity as well as the daily gastro-politics are analyzed as factors that influence authority, intimacy and social boundaries in a Tamil Brahmin family kitchen during a festival meal.

### **Describing the Situation**

In the Tamil Brahmin upper-caste festival kitchen, a social rank is very rigid the senior female holds authority and does all the chief decision making, junior females do most of the cooking, males are generally excluded and in terms of seating and serving, the high rank guests are given precedence over the poor ones and is the last to eat. According to Appadurai (1981), the Tamil Brahmin food practices, which are based on the sacred hearth, can be considered as an epitome of both ritual and kinship politics, where cooking and eating create social differences into existence.



**Figure 1.** *Traditional interior of a Tamil–Brahmin household kitchen featuring brass vessels and ritual cookware.*

### **Aestheticization of Women Labour and Gendered Authority.**

Women physically control the kitchen but not symbolically. Cooking is created as a gendered and moral responsibility of the wife to her husband, according to Appadurai (1981), it will be marked by men being served first, sitting in privileged places and not having to participate in any labour of food preparation. Gendered power then, is one of contradictions that women are in charge of the most important part of household life but in a hierarchy that identifies their labour as service

but not as power. The given observation reveals that the act of feeding is rooted in women's labour and is subordinated but centralized (Appadurai, 1981).

Ray (2009) emphasises the aestheticisation of the cooking of women in colonial Bengal, in which cooking, taste, sophistication, and devotion were connected to the activity, which remains the rule in contemporary Tamil Brahmin kitchens. Ray tells of another use of taste as a way of class separation, much like upper-caste vegetarianism claims its moral superiority. Srinivas (2013) further contends that women are able to bargain this challenging domesticity by transforming culinary knowledge into an agency and public value, which makes kitchen work both restrictive and empowering at the same time.

Therefore, the art of cooking, learning to make a perfectly spiced rasam, turns out to be a simple assessment of the moral value of a daughter-in-law and her failure is an object of criticism. According to Appadurai (1981), this dynamic is one of the main gastro-political battlefields, the struggle between the mother-in-law and the daughter-in-law, in which the share of food, especially of ghee, is a real political element. The younger women tend to compensate for this power with minor opposition (hoarding, changing recipes, or slowing down service) so as to show that women are also dynamic agents in the food hierarchy, despite being subordinated to it.

### **Purity, Pollution and the Organization of Space.**

The purity in this kitchen is not only symbolic but also spatial, physical, and procedural. Only ritual purified people could go close to the hearth. Before cooking, women are required to take a shower, put on new saris, braid hair and take off shoes. Menstruating women are not allowed to do any cooking duties at all, what Appadurai (1981) calls the moral aspects of any particular part of food, the bodies are classified as pure or impure based on the cosmological codes (Appadurai, 1981). Since the body is a source of disciplined moral states, appadurai observes that it is purity that regulates the body into visible states of morality.

Some of the relatives are deemed to be impure because of their eating styles or caste affiliations. They are forced to be farther away from the fire, are served on watered curries rather than fat ones, or they are late feeders. Left overs are given to servants in different plates, a situation in the temple case where non-Brahmins were offered prasadam as they were served like dogs and cattles (Appadurai, 1981). Purity thus regulates the acquaintance and space in a surgical manner.

The article by Ray (2009) helps us to realize how the concept of purity combined with the standards of aesthetics the modern cookbooks in colonial Bengal that she discusses were focused on hygiene and order as signs of a civilized woman. This dynamic trend is quite evident in the Tamil Brahmin kitchen, where ritual purity is combined with middle-class concepts of discipline and good housekeeping. In addition, cleanliness became an indicator of good femininity as a combination of purity and modernity (Ray, 2009).



and devotion. According to Appadurai (1981), purity creates graded emotions, with shame, disgust, and reverence being the indices of social status. A food practice is based on emotional registers such as the feeling of pride and humiliation to organize the social life. Although gendered labor brings in a sense of hierarchy, through the proposed selfless service of women, it also enables them to have their own weapons of resistance, that they can play minor negotiations with patriarchy (Appadurai, 1981; Ray, 2010).

Lastly, the kitchen establishes social categories of the us and them. As Ray (2009) observes taste as a characteristic of Bengali middle class, Brahmin vegetarianism and artisanal methods lay moral down on the lower castes and the rest, and thus represent social disparity in food.

## **Conclusion**

Through an analysis of Tamil Brahmin household kitchen, one can understand that food practices are not only culinary practices but also a political practice that governs authority, emotions and social relationships. The concept of gastro-politics developed by Appadurai (1981) reveals the struggle and subordination embedded into the choreography of cooking and serving, whereas the analysis of Ray (2009), demonstrates how the aestheticization of women labour makes patriarchy seem natural. Both gendered expectations and purity rules are used to create a social world where intimacy and authority are discussed via food. As per Appadurai (1981), food is an ethical substance, which determines love, discipline, and power. In this way, the kitchen is turned into a moralized space, a space where individual traits become visible, hierarchy is acted out and the boundaries of the community are constantly re-enforced. Food is not a neutral thing; it is the medium of expression of the most profound values of social life and criticism of them.

## References

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